New Orleans Area Habitat For Humanity: A Lifeline For Post-Katrina New Orleans

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This interview was conducted with Marguerite Oestreicher, Executive Director, New Orleans Area Habitat for Humanity.

At the center of Hurricane Katrina's devastation was its complete demolition of the city's neighborhoods and sacred residential spaces. The New Orleans Area Habitat for Humanity found itself at the forefront of recovery, as it was the first organization to receive a residential construction permit after the storm.

Habitat has served the New Orleans area for over 40 years as an independent affiliate of Habitat for Humanity International. Prior to Hurricane Katrina, Habitat built a modest 10 homes annually. By 2007, Habitat became the largest home builder in Louisiana. From 2006 - 2008, Habitat saw its production increase so much that the organization had built more than 200 homes during that span alone. And the city and its people have continued to inspire the organization, even 20 years later.

Habitat for Humanity provides affordable homes for purchase to qualified buyers who apply to their program. The home-buying process includes financial literacy education, home maintenance training, and other programs for both buyers and builders.

As sustainability continues to be a key priority for Habitat, the organization has expanded its services beyond facilitating homeownership. The organization now offers repair services, home preservation, and maintenance support to help buyers care for their homes after purchase.

Even further into the community, Habitat ReStore is its very own shopping center that features gently used items available at a fraction of their original cost. Products, including furniture, building materials, and even recycled paint, can be found at the ReStore. By selling these items, Habitat has managed to divert over one million cubic yards of potential waste from landfills. These initiatives are all proof that Habitat for Humanity builds homes while fostering strong communities.

Q: Hurricane Katrina displaced so many families and disrupted communities. How did the New Orleans Area Habitat for Humanity help contribute to the strengthening of what was lost in the city?

Marguerite Oestreicher: That is a huge question, and worthy of the scale and magnitude of devastation brought by [Hurricane] Katrina. I, like so many others in this wonderful, blessed community, lost my home, so I have that lived experience. You know, that trauma stays with you, even 20 years later. And there are days when someone might ask a small, random question, and I find myself utterly overwhelmed by grief. Our city is different now than she was before, but she perseveres because as a community and as a people, we are strong, we are resilient, and we are persistent. However, we are also resourceful and incredibly generous, and when the chips are down, everyone steps up to help their neighbor. And, I will be forever grateful for that lived experience.

Habitat has been instrumental in the city's long-term recovery after Hurricane Katrina, and we have been working ever since. Prior to Katrina, the New Orleans Area Habitat for Humanity was a small affiliate building about 10 houses a year. But when [Hurricane] Katrina hit, the need was in front of everyone, so the organization had to scale up and do so fairly quickly. And, this was only made possible through many, many factors, including the entire world stepping up to help New Orleans. Everyone stepped up in the form of money and gifts so quickly that we could hardly get 'Thank Yous' out or keep records of all of these donations/gifts. During the immediate aftermath of the storm, Habitat had about 1,000 volunteers daily. By 2007, we became the largest homebuilder in the state in terms of volume.

Q: How has the grant money from BCM helped the New Orleans Area Habitat for Humanity's mission and purpose?

Oestreicher: One of the greatest struggles for any nonprofit is unrestricted funding, because you always have needs that do not fit the strict confines of most sources of funding. The BCM grant allowed us to distribute that funding and laser-target it to specific areas of need. For example, an elderly homeowner may need repairs, or our education and outreach programming needs revamping. Having this flexibility was a phenomenal gift, and it just made a tremendous difference to the organization. And, it allowed us to help more people than our traditional budget. I credit BCM for stepping into this space, funding grants, because everyone wants to be a good steward of other people's money. Historically, for foundations, that meant telling us exactly how you are going to use the funds, so that we can share that with our donors. And, when you shift to what I call a 'trust' model, where a foundation has identified organizations that have a long history and deliver on promise, it's the future path to philanthropy. Getting that gift from BCM gave our team such a lift.

Q: There are a lot of forces pulling people, especially young people, away from New Orleans. How does your work give people a reason to stay and invest in this city?

Oestreicher: I think all of us need to be thinking for this community to not just survive but thrive. We need opportunities for our young people. Our young people graduate, but then they move away. We need good jobs, but we also need a path where they can see a future here, where they can own a home and start a family. Only 21% of homes in the United States now go to first-time homebuyers. That is an astounding statistic. The median age of a first-time home buyer in 2025 is now 40-years-old. In New Orleans, the median price of a home is now between $330,000-$350,000. So, there is this huge disconnect, and there are not enough pathways to create opportunities for younger adults to become homeowners. That's a really big deal, and it really matters. It is a huge piece of why Habitat's work is so important, because if you don't have opportunities to purchase homes. And yes, our costs, materials, labor, have all gone up, but the fact that we don't have to bake in a profit, that's helping keep our prices more manageable for people who I would call the 'missing middle.' These are people who are wage earners, and they make too much to get vouchers or other kinds of subsidies, but not enough to break that cycle of renting. And, these are the people who Habitat serves.

Q: When you think about the next 20 years, what role do you see your organization playing in the continued recovery and reimaging of New Orleans? What lessons have been learned?

Oestreicher: I don't think anyone can responsibly speak to the next 20. The pace of change has rapidly accelerated, in an environmental way, in terms of climate change. And when I say climate change, it doesn't just mean a hurricane. It can be a spring rain where an area receives over four inches in a couple of hours and floods streets. It can be extreme heat. There could also be droughts.

The takeaway for disaster planning is that you plan for the things you know about, but you also have to retain a degree of flexibility to respond to those unexpected things that can happen. So, you can plan ahead for the basics, like ensuring tight communications. For example, when Hurricane Ida hit, we invested in satellite phones because we knew what it was like to not have cellular service for weeks during Hurricane Katrina in 2005.

Hurricane Katrina fundamentally changed the way we think about not only where we build, but also the way we build. Three years ago, we started building to a fortified gold standard (not just the roof, but also impact-resistant windows), the first in the state to do so. Our mission is to responsibly build communities where families can thrive in homes they can afford.

Affording a home isn't just getting to the closing table. It also means building a better house, so that there is less maintenance and that it will do better in the next big weather event, ultimately reducing the cost to own it. And when you build a better house, it also costs less to insure. Building to a fortified gold standard costs more, but when we look at the impact for the buyer, we 100% believe it is worth that investment.

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Your support makes this work possible. A gift of any size helps New Orleans Area Habitat for Humanity continue serving the community and building a stronger, more resilient city for everyone.

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